Dale and I resumed our innings on the last morning, determined to make England fight for every wicket and still harbouring hope of getting away with a draw. I played back to the third delivery of the day, but the ball skidded on quicker than I expected and struck me on the pad. Moeen Ali appealed and the umpire raised his finger. I called for the decision to be reviewed, more in hope than expectation … to no avail. I was out.

The next hour or so unfolded as one of the more depressing experiences of my career; our last five wickets fell for 28 runs in the space of 24 overs, and we were defeated by 241 runs. I have never minded losing. I have never minded being beaten by the better team. You accept it and move on. However, on this dismal morning in Durban, with the songs of several thousand England supporters echoing around an otherwise deserted ground, it started to look as though, for the first time in my memory, a Proteas team was losing without a fight.

I know that wasn't the case. I know we were all trying. However, I am simply saying there was a perception that, collectively, we had lacked the appetite for a battle – and that perception hurt.

Frank conversations followed and, on the first day of the second Test in Cape Town, we seemed to be competing more intensely. England won an important toss and batted first on a flat wicket, but KG took three wickets and we were reasonably content to have England at 223 for five at drinks in the evening session.

We were then subjected to one of the most extraordinary batting assaults. Ben Stokes and Jonny Bairstow batted for the last hour of the first day and into the second, adding 399 runs in 59 overs. Stokes struck the ball magnificently and his epic innings of 258 included 30 boundaries and 11 sixes. We were wilting under the onslaught, and Bairstow reached 150 not out before England declared at 629 for six.

'AB, can I have a word with you?' our captain asked.

'Sure, Hash, no problem.'